

BEFORE

The Afro-European slave trade began in around 1440, when Portuguese traders began to ship captured Africans to work on plantations, to feed Europe's growing demand for sugar.

SUGAR PLANTATIONS

The first sugar plantation was established by the Portuguese in Madeira, an island off the northwest coast of Africa, in 1452. At first, Africans were kidnapped and forced into slavery to work on plantations, but in 1458 a deal was brokered with African rulers to purchase slaves. Up to the mid-17th century, 90 percent of the 140,000 slaves imported from Africa were bought by the sugar planters of the West African islands (the Canaries, Madeira, São Tomé, and Cape Verde). The rest were shipped to the Americas.

SUGAR CANE



The triangular trade

The global triangular trading system had profit on every leg. Slave ships left European ports for West Africa laden with iron, wine, guns, and textiles. These were exchanged for slaves, who were transported across the Atlantic to sell to plantation owners. The ships then returned to European ports with a cargo of sugar, coffee, and tobacco.



KEY

Slave routes

- European slave traders
- Arab slave traders
- Ottoman slave traders
- African slaving centers

Goods routes

- Tobacco, sugar, cotton
- Metals, tobacco, sugar, coffee
- Iron, cloth, shells, guns

NECK RING



FOOT SHACKLES



The Slave Trade

The brutal trade in African slaves began in the mid-15th century and reached its height in the 18th century. All together, around 10 million Africans were captured, shackled, and shipped to the Americas to work on sugar, cotton, and tobacco plantations.

Although African slave labor was used in the production of other commodities, such as minerals, coffee, cocoa, indigo, cotton, and tobacco, it was Europe's craving for sugar that brought European traders to Africa to buy and barter slaves. The Swedes, Danes, French, British, Dutch, and Portuguese established over 30 slave forts along the West African "Gold Coast," and a series of ports for exporting slaves stretched over 2,000 miles (3,200 km) from the Senegal River south to Angola in Senegambia, Dahomey (Benin), and Ouidah.

Slaves in Africa

Slavery was already part of Africa's tribal economy and society—more so than land ownership—before the arrival of the European traders. For example, women and children whose menfolk had been killed in battle were usually enslaved, becoming part of a tribal ruler's extended family. The East Africa slave trade was also well-established, with captured slaves transported north across the Saharan desert and east into Arabia, the Middle East, and India by Arab and Ottoman slave traders.

African chiefs were complicit in providing the European seafarers with slaves. However, they did not want the Europeans to settle inland. (In any case, the Europeans themselves were deterred by the difficulties of travel in Africa's interior, and the threat of disease.) As a result, African chiefs leased out land along the coast so the Europeans could establish trading forts. African slaves captured in raids or after battle were transported to the forts by their African captors, then sold to the European traders. Some African rulers were especially accommodating. For

Instruments of torture

Slaves were seen as chattel, or goods, not as human beings, demonstrated by the assortment of heavy iron shackles that they had to endure. Male slaves were chained up in gruesome ankle and neck chains.

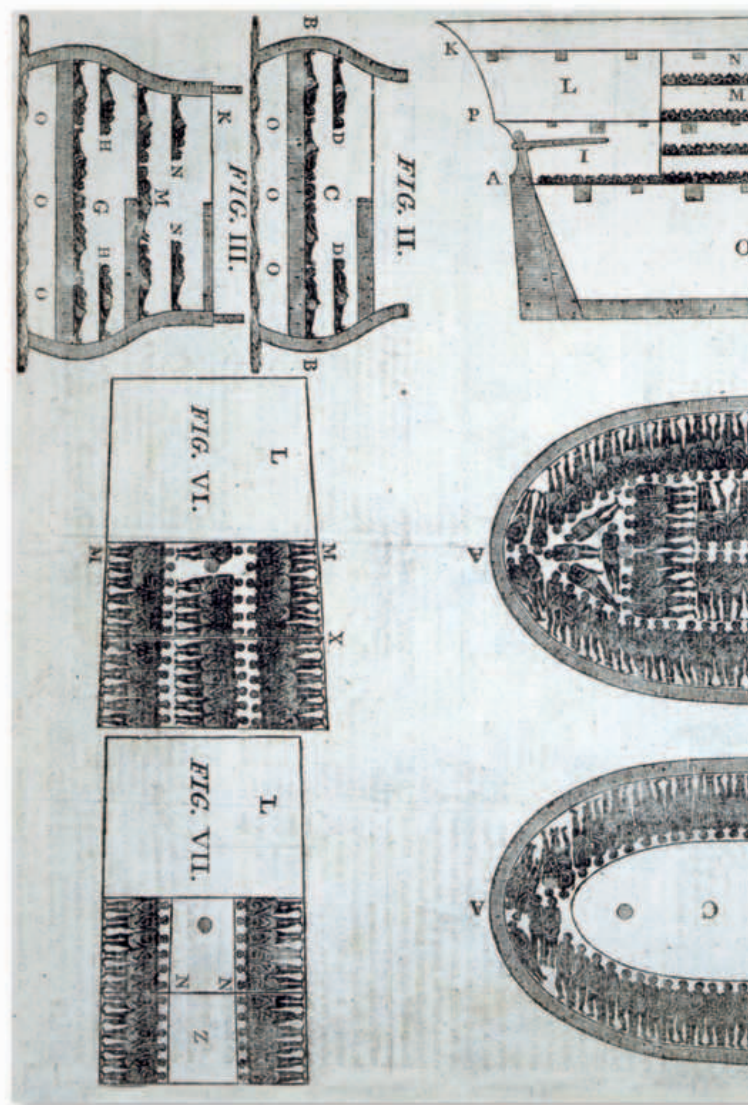
example, in 1726 the King of Dahomey suggested that the Europeans should establish plantations in his kingdom—he would supply the slaves.

Money without morals

With only a toehold on the African coast, Europeans were unable to monopolize the slave trade. Slaves

Slave ship

This horrific image shows how many slaves could be packed into the hold of the slave ship, *Brookes*, to maximize profit. In 1789, anti-slavery campaigners published 700 posters of the drawing, sparking the beginning of the end of the slave trade in Britain.



"There was nothing to be heard but the **rattling of chains**, smacking of whips and groans and **cries** of our... men."

OTTOBAH CUGOANO, FREED SLAVE, 1787